challenged the BJP saying, 'if the pro-Hindu organisations of the country themselves do not respect Buddha, assassinate Mahatma Gandhi, demolish mosques and Buddhist *stupas*, how can they expect Taliban to listen to them and stop the destruction of the two giant statues?'[12] The *Shahi Imam* of Delhi's Jama Masjid, Syed Ahmad Bukhari, took this further by publicly announcing his willingness to negotiate with the Taliban to hand over the statues on the condition that Vajpayee would accept the demolition of the Babri Masjid as a national shame. Linking the demolition of the Buddhas to Babri Masjid, Bukhari implored that 'the Taliban action should be seen in totality and not in isolation.'[13] But the advocacy of opening an informal channel with the Taliban, for whatever reason and advocated by whomsoever, had long been dead. On 9 March 2001, after consulting with various heads of states, the UNSC, and the UN Secretary General, India co-sponsored a UNGA resolution[14] calling upon the Taliban to abide by its commitments to protect Afghanistan's cultural heritage.[15] Nothing came of it.

Instead, the Taliban justified the act on grounds of Western hypocrisy and provocations. Sayed Ramatullah Hashimi, Taliban envoy in the US, along with Mullah Abdul Saleem Zaeef, Taliban envoy to Pakistan, put the blame on a delegation of European diplomats that had recently visited Kabul.[16] With a drought-like situation and a long winter staring them in the face, millions of Afghans faced the prospect of starvation that year. Instead of offering financial support for starving Afghan children, the European delegation offered money to repair and maintain the Buddhas. When the Taliban sought that money in the form of humanitarian aid the delegation balked, outraging the Taliban. 'When your children are dying in front of you, then you don't care about a piece of art', bellowed Hashimi.[17] He did not mention the Indian offer to extract these artifacts and a Japanese offer to purchase them, the financial proceeds of which could go towards feeding starving Afghans.[18] The fact was that the Taliban, with support from and under the ideological influence of Al Qaeda, had begun to clamp down heavily on Afghanistan's religious minority communities and women.

In May 2001, the Taliban issued another decree against the Hindu and Sikh communities of Afghanistan. Hindu men were debarred from wearing *salwar*